Deerfield Intelligence | Director of Operations - Case Study

Operational Gap Assessment

Through my meetings with all available stakeholders, I have identified the operational gaps across functions and summarized my findings below. When determining how to assign priority levels to each gap, I considered (i) if the matter was raised independently by multiple stakeholders, (ii) any dependencies between gaps (e.g. leveling framework should underpin recruiting and compensation processes), and (iii) any associated regulatory or liability exposure.

Operational Gap	Reported by	What's happening today	Why it matters as we scale	Priority Level
Human Resources:				
1. Onboarding	DC, ER	* Highly disorganized process, resulting in delayed platform access for new hires and frustration amongst current pod leads	* Significant hiring planned * Important to demonstrate organizational cohesion from day #1 to support team culture and employee retention	High - quick win opportunity; new hire starting in 2 weeks
2. Leveling	ER	* No clear structure defining skill levels across existing team or open roles	* Need to build a well-balanced team that offers opportunities for career growth and sets expectations around upward mobility	High - underpins other gaps (e.g. recruiting)
3. Recruiting	DC, ER	* Inconsistent recruiting workflows due to lack of centralized ownership, resulting in poor candidate experience / process dropoff	* Significant hiring planned * Important to demonstrate organizational cohesion to attract talented candidates	High - actively hiring for 5 open roles
4. Performance management	ER	* No performance review protocol, which creates uncertainty around compensation level and promotion opportunities	* Clarified career paths / promotion opportunities are an important driver of long-term retention	Medium - low near-term attrition risk
5. Culture	ER	* Intelligence team is fairly siloed from the rest of the Deerfield organization	* Visibility and connectivity supports employee satisfaction and retention	Low - longer term

		* No formal initiatives to establish culture and connectivity within Intelligence team	* Improved visibility across the broader firm should benefit the Intelligence team's resourcing	investment
Finance / Procurement:				
6. Vendor management	DC, PS, JO, SK	* No standardized review process for new vendors, which leads to unnecessary spend (e.g. duplicative tools and expensive auto-renewals), as well as compliance risks (e.g. illegally sourced vendor data)	* Without visibility into vendor exposure, risk of cost bloat and/or compliance violation grows significantly as team scales	High - Cross-functional impact; quick win opportunity
7. Budget accuracy & visibility	DC, PS, JO	* No consistent visibility into drivers of variance vs. budget * No cost allocation infrastructure by pod or project, which inhibits ability to assess the 'ROI' of specific initiatives	* Important to clarify Intelligence team's allocation of resources and associated ROI with Deerfield leadership	Medium - support annual planning for CY2027
Compliance:				
8. Regulatory oversight	SK	* No inventory of team's active AI / ML models, which is expected under SEC examination priorities on AI governance	* SEC is increasingly focused on AI / ML model governance	High - urgent need for SEC readiness
9. Project deployment standards	MT, SK	* Inconsistent protocol when Intelligence team deploys tools to Deerfield portfolio companies, which creates uncertainty around liability and ongoing support needs	* Standardizing deployment protocol will be critical in managing team's liability as scope expands	High - external liability exposure
10. Data / info. sharing standards	SK	* Limited team awareness of safe usage standards with third-party tools * Weak controls around sharing of sensitive information amongst broader Deerfield org	* Risk of breach increases as team expands	Low - reduced risk at current team scale
Operations / 'Ways of Working':				
11. Prioritization / resource allocation	DC, PS, MT,	* No standard protocol for investment team	* Effective project prioritization and	High -

	SK	or portfolio companies to request Intelligence team support on new initiatives * Intelligence team leadership has limited awareness of active projects across team, which inhibits effective prioritization * Inconsistent cadence of communication across teams (e.g. engineering, finance, HR, compliance) results in reactive firedrills	resource allocation is foundational to the continued growth and success of the team	all initiatives rely on improved cross-functional visibility and coordination

Legend - DC: David Chen // PS: Priya Sharma // MT: Marcus Thompson // ER: Elena Rodriguez // JO: James Okonkwo // SK: Sarah Kim

90-day Operational Plan

Category	Type	Timing	Initiative Detail
Human Resources:			
Onboarding	Process	day 1 - 30	* Create 'Deerfield Intelligence 101' materials (e.g. via Notion page) that outlines key contacts across organization, list of active platforms / tools, 'ways of working' standards (e.g. protocol for shipping code) * Coordinate with pod leads to map out active platforms (e.g. Slack, GitHub, AWS environments, etc) to inform onboarding workflows * Create automated onboarding workflow that triggers coordination between hiring manager, HR and Ops to ensure new hire has required tech tools (e.g. laptop, monitor), platform access and support materials on day 1. Workflow to include scheduling of welcome lunch and HR/Ops intro calls during first week
Leveling	Process	day 1 - 30	* HR to draft leveling framework and compensation band benchmarking for David's review * Work with David to apply leveling to the existing team to support go-forward performance management * Incorporate leveling into recruiting processes to ensure terms of new hire offers are aligned to framework
Recruiting	Process	day 1 - 30	* Create automated workflow for hiring processes that clarifies the stages of the interview process (i.e. team lead by stage, key evaluation criteria by stage, etc), organizes feedback across all interviewers, and facilitates review/signoff required to move candidates forward through final offer * Note - longer term opportunity (i.e. post-90 days) to build a 'talent community' and establish a warm

			pipeline of prospective candidates (e.g. former colleagues of team members, prior interview candidates that made final round, graduate programs, etc)
Performance mgmt.	Process + Ritual	day 31 - 60	* Introduce semi-annual performance reviews based on a *streamlined* version of leading tech companies that Intelligence team came from (e.g. Google, Palantir, Amazon) * HR to introduce a performance improvement plan (PIP) framework based on protocol from broader Deerfield organization
Culture	Rituals	day 61 - 90	* Establish new formats for Intelligence team to engage with broader Deerfield organization in a more impactful manner (e.g. technical demos) * Launch initiatives to foster Intelligence team cohesion and fulfillment (e.g. team offsites focused on impact validation; regularly scheduled 'innovation time' blocks)
Finance / Procurement:			
Vendor mgmt.	Process + System	day 1 - 30	* Vet existing vendor contracts and create a summary dashboard to support cross-functional visibility. Dashboard to capture vendor scope, contract execution date, duration, renewal terms, cancellation terms, pod allocation, portfolio company allocation (if applicable), vendor data source(s), PHI/PII exposure ● Flag existing vendor contracts with auto-renewal terms to Finance ● Review cloud spend (i.e. AWS, GCP) with pod leaders to confirm utilization needs and streamline current spend ($30k/mo) * Implement standardized review and execution process for new vendor contracts **[**see Prototype tool for process details]**
Budgeting	System + Ritual	day 31 - 60	* Collaborate with Finance and pod leaders to review existing spend (e.g. employees, vendors, etc.) to allocate to either the investment or portfolio pod, where applicable * New vendor spend to be automatically assigned pod allocation via the new vendor review process referenced above
Compliance:			
Deployments	Process	day 1 - 30	* Work with Compliance to develop standardized deployment frameworks for portfolio company projects. Frameworks to clarify liability exposure and ongoing scope of Intelligence team
Data / info sharing	Process	day 61 - 90	* Compliance to create a 'data handling & ethics' guide that explains limitations around information sharing with third-party AI tools, and outlines communication standards across the broader Deerfield organization (e.g. using protected Slack channels for sharing MNPI).

			• Employees to review 'data handling & ethics' guide during new hire onboarding and annually thereafter • Create Slack channels with restricted access for sharing sensitive project information
Operations / 'Ways of Working':			
Project intake	Process	day 1 - 30	* Introduce standardized submission process for new project requests from investment team and portfolio companies. Work with pod leaders to roll out new process to stakeholder groups
Project tracker	System + Ritual	day 1 - 30	* Build and maintain a centralized tracker of all active projects to support cross-functional visibility and collaboration. Tracker to include standard summary information (e.g. project scope, working group, key stakeholders (i.e. investment team vs. portfolio company), kickoff date, target completion date, upcoming milestones, etc.) as well as compliance-specific requirements for SEC review support (e.g. data flow diagram, access permissions, information sensitivity level, AI / ML model training information)

Cross-functional Coordination Model

As the Director of Operations, I would operate as the single front door between the Intelligence team and the central functions. Each function gets to work with one accountable counterpart rather than 10+ engineers, pod leaders would be able to stay focused on strategy and execution, and every recurring interaction would run through a defined process, a shared system, or a scheduled ritual rather than an ad hoc Slack. The ultimate goal is to provide consistent visibility across stakeholders and minimize the 'reactive firedrills' that are currently pervasive.

Function	Counterpart(s)	Key focus areas	Rituals
Human Resources	ER	Leveling framework (e.g. comp benchmarks); recruiting (e.g. candidate sourcing, offer documentation); new hire onboarding logistics; performance management administration; culture initiative implementation	Weekly recruiting & onboarding sync: HR, Ops Semi-annual performance reviews
Finance	JO	Vendor review / contract negotiation; annual budgeting; budget vs. actuals review	Monthly budget vs actuals review: Finance, Ops, Pod leads Annual budget planning

Compliance	SK	Vendor due diligence / contract review; privacy reviews; deployment support; information sharing protocol	Monthly project tracker review: Compliance, Ops, Pod leads
Intelligence Leadership	DC, PS, MT	Weekly review of project tracker and new project submission requests to assess latest prioritization, dependencies and scope creep risk	Weekly project tracker review: Ops, Pod leads, David

Decision	David Chen	Pod Leads	Ops	HR	Finance	Compliance
Open a new role	Accountable	Consulted	Responsible	Consulted	Informed	–
Approve a new vendor	Informed	Consulted	Accountable	–	Consulted	Consulted
Deploy model to PortCo	Accountable	Responsible	Consulted	–	–	Consulted
Allocate pod capacity to new project	Accountable	Responsible	Consulted	–	Informed	–
Semi-annual performance reviews	Accountable	Consulted	Consulted	Responsible	–	–
Annual budgeting process	Accountable	Consulted	Consulted	–	Responsible	–

Prototype Tool

For the prototype, I chose to build the vendor review workflow referenced in gap #6 and the 90-day plan. It was the clearest case where a single tool could address a problem raised independently by nearly all of the stakeholders I interviewed (i.e. Finance, Compliance, pod leads and David). Today new vendors are onboarded without a consistent review protocol, which results in duplicative spend, accidental auto-renewals, and compliance and data risks. The prototype I developed gives each function a single place to submit, review, and approve a vendor, with every lead's review status visible at a glance. Once all stakeholders have approved the vendor, the contract is released to Ops for execution and uploading to the centralized vendor dashboard.
This prototype was built in Lovable over a few hours and is intentionally scoped as a working demo rather than a production system. The repository README describes how the prototype currently runs, and what would need to be added (e.g. authentication, per-role permissions, Slack and email integration) before live contracts move through it.

GitHub repository: LINK